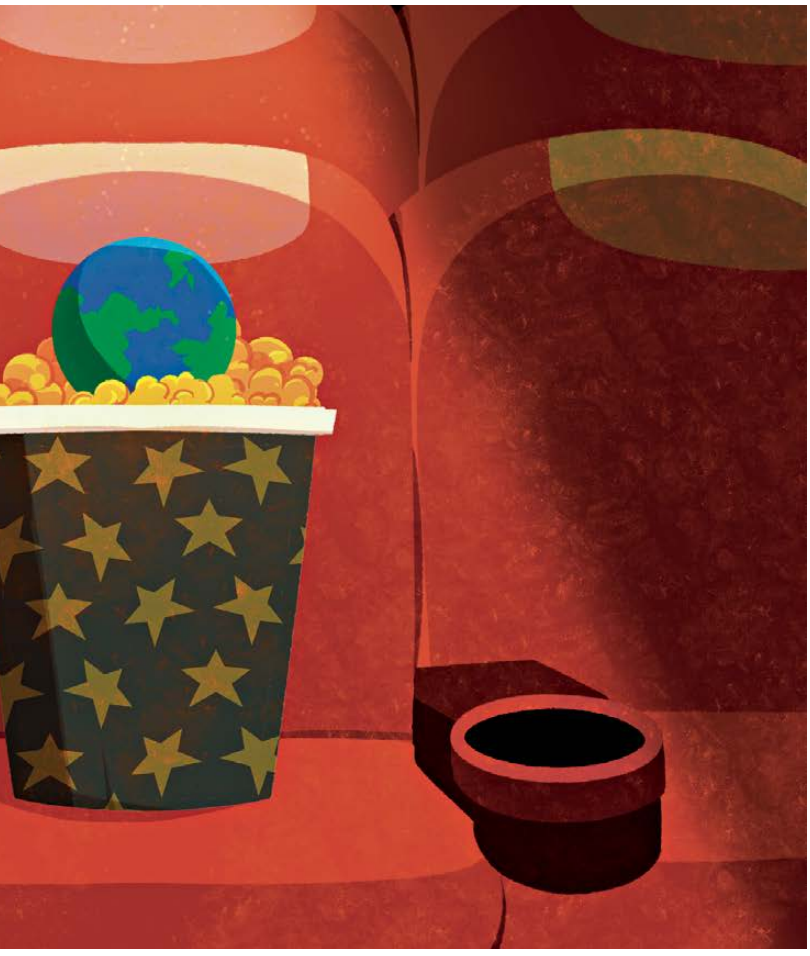


Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

world of rich Indians. The 2010s marked a resurgence of independent cinema in India. Directors like Vikramaditya Motwane (*Udaan*), Vasan Bala (*Peddlers*), Ritesh Batra (*The Lunchbox*), Neeraj Ghaywan (*Masaan*), and Shlok Sharma (*Haraamkhor*) emerged, bringing fresh and innovative perspectives to the canvas of Indian films. During this period, independent filmmakers faced significant challenges with distribution and visibility. The struggle for screen space and theatrical runs was compounded by limited digital rights deals, making it difficult to reach wider audiences.

I recall my own experiences during this period, where the distribution of independent films was a major hurdle. In 2012, I sold the rights of *Gangs of Wasseypur* to Netflix, not as a two-part film but as an eight-part mini-series. This was a pioneering move, marking the first Hindi-language series on the platform. The advent of OTT platforms like Netflix and Amazon Prime Video has significantly influenced the diversity of Indian cinema. They have made it easier to access films from different regions, bridging gaps that previously existed. The pandemic further accelerated this shift, enabling audiences to explore diverse films from the comfort of their homes.

Bridging language barriers: "Once you overcome the one-inch-tall barrier of subtitles, you will be introduced to so many more amazing films," director Bong Joon-ho had said in his Golden Globes acceptance speech in 2020. He spoke for all of us filmmakers who try to tell stories as grounded and true to their intent as possible. To further push Indian cinema to a global audience, overcoming language barriers is crucial. Additionally, nurturing global partnerships with film festivals and distribution networks can introduce Indian films to new markets while emphasising unique cultural narratives that resonate universally. Koreans have mastered this better than anyone else in the world. The hype around K-dramas is real.

As we navigate the post-pandemic world, the dynamics of film distribution and consumption continue to evolve. The decline in linear TV rights and the growing importance of digital rights highlight a shift in how films are financed and recovered. Despite the challenges faced by theatrical releases, there are still remarkable successes. Films like *Laapataa Ladies, 12th Fail, Munjya*, and *Kill* have made a strong impact on audiences across India, though some have struggled to gain widespread theatrical success.

Going global: But if I were to define my favourite moment in Indian cinema, it would be the 2023 Oscars—where films like S.S. Rajamouli's *RRR*, Shaunak Sen's *All That Breathes*, and Kartiki Gonsalves's *The Elephant Whisperers* collectively represented India on the global stage. The recognition these films received is a testament to the richness and diversity of Indian cinema. This year, independent Indian filmmakers continued to make waves internationally. Payal Kapadia's *All We Imagine As Light* won the prestigious Grand Prix at the 77th Cannes Film Festival, while Vinay Shukla's Peabody Award-winning *While We Watched* and TIFF's People's Choice Award: Midnight Madness-winning *Kill* garnered global recognition, also becoming the first Hindi film to get a broad theatrical release in the US. These films, discovered at renowned film festivals like Sundance, Cannes, and TIFF, have received critical acclaim and highlighted the growing interest in Indian stories worldwide.

Documenting difficulties: Despite the promising successes of independent filmmakers in the recent past, documentary filmmaking in India still faces challenges. Historically underfunded, documentaries often rely on international funds, TV channels, and independent productions. The rise of streaming platforms has provided much-needed support, making documentaries more accessible and appreciated by regular audiences. Netflix, in particular,